Indefinite Relative Pronouns

An **indefinite pronoun** refers to people/things/ideas without saying exactly who or what they are. In the case of relative pronouns, when there is no specific antecedent for the relative pronoun to refer to, keyword **ce** is combined with the relative pronoun to form **indefinite relative pronouns.**

Characteristics of Indefinite Relative Pronoun

- Refers to indefinite things.
- They do not have gender or number, as they are indefinite (not defined).
- Can be subjects, objects or objects of preposition.
- Are impersonal & invariable.

Ce qui, **ce que**, **ce dont**, **ce à quoi** translate to **what.**

Ce Que (What)

Ce que serves as the indefinite **direct object** for the dependent clause.

Français	English
Je comprends **ce que** vous dites.	I understand **what** you are saying.
Ivana fait **ce qu**'elle veut.	Ivana does **what** she wants.
Dis-moi tout **ce que** tu as expériencé.	Tell me everything (**what**) you've experienced.
Racontez-moi tout **ce que** vous faites.	Tell me everything (**what**) you do.

Ce Qui (What)

Ce qui serves as the indefinite **subject** for the dependent clause.

Français	English
Je ne sais pas **ce qui** s'est passé.	I don't know **what** happened.
Personne ne sait **ce qui** a causé l'accident.	Nobody knows **what** caused the accident.
Il doit découvrir **ce qui** a favorisé le changement.	He must find out **what** promotes this change.
Tu dois comprendre **ce qui** compte le plus dans la vie.	You need to figure out **what** matters the most in life.

Note: In compound tenses, the past participle does not accord with the gender/number of the object/antecedent because **"ce qui"** and **"ce que"** refer to indefinite things.

Ce Dont (What/That)

“Ce dont” serves as the indefinite **indirect object of the preposition “de”** for the dependent clause.

Français	English
Vous ne savez pas **ce dont** il est capable.	You don’t know **what** he is capable of.
Tu sais **ce dont** Soha parle ?	Do you know **what** Soha is talking about?
Heureusement, j’ai tout **ce dont** j’ai besoin.	Fortunately, I have everything **that** I need.
Je ne comprends pas **ce dont** elle a peur.	I don’t know **what** she is scared of.
Personne ne sait **ce dont** Donald est fier.	Nobody knows **what** Donald is proud of.
Dites-nous **ce dont** vous vous souvenez.	Tell us **what** you remember.

Preposition + Quoi as Indefinite Relative Pronoun

Sometimes: preposition + quoi can serve as the indefinite **indirect object for prepositions other than “de”** for the dependent clause. The use of **“ce”** is optional here.

Français	English
Je voudrais savoir **à quoi** elle pense. Je voudrais savoir **ce à quoi** elle pense.	I would like to know what she is thinking about.
N'oubliez jamais **avec quoi** nous avons commencé cette entreprise. N'oubliez jamais **ce avec quoi** nous avons commencé cette entreprise.	Never forget what we began this company with.
Montre-moi **sur quoi** tu as travaillé hier. Montre-moi **ce sur quoi** tu as travaillé hier.	Show me what you worked on yesterday.

Tout + Indefinite Relative Pronouns (Everything/All That)

The pronoun “**tout**” is used with indefinite relative pronouns, it translates to **“everything”** or **“all”**.

Français	English
J’aime **tout ce que** Charlotte aime.	I like **everything that** Charlotte likes.
Ta santé est **tout ce qui** compte en ce moment.	Your health is **everything/all that** matters at this moment.

Ils comprennent **tout ce dont** le professeur parle.	They understand **everything that** the professor talks about.
J'explique **tout ce à quoi** cette initiative sert.	I'll explain **everything that** this initiative serves.
J'aime beaucoup mon ami mais je ne suis pas d'accord avec **tout ce qu'**il dit.	I really love my friend but I don't agree with **everything (that)** he says.

Indefinite Relative Pronouns for Emphasis

They can be placed in the beginning of a sentence to emphasize a point.

Français	English
Ce que je veux, c'est la paix.	**What** I want is peace.
Ce que tu as acheté hier, c'est la nouvelle édition de Vogue, non ?	**What** you bought yesterday is the new edition of Vogue, isn't it?
Ce qui est amusant, c'est l'épisode précédent de Modern Family, n'est-ce pas ?	**What** is funny is the previous episode of Modern Family, isn't it?
Ce à quoi il s'intéresse, c'est la vie privée de sa voisine.	**What** he is interested in is his neighbour's private life.
Ce dont j'ai besoin, c'est une tasse de thé et un bon livre à la main.	**What** I need is a cup of tea and a good book at hand.
Ce qui m'ennuie, c'est que je n'ai pas reçu de nouvelles.	**What** bothers me is that I haven't heard any news.